Thesis Proposal Planning Worksheet

CFAN 3091V | Working answers, evidence, and next decisions

Name: _____ **Date:** _____

Due: Wednesday, November 4, 2026, at the beginning of class. Hand in on paper.

Use this with the **Thesis Proposal: Guiding Questions** resource. Begin in Monday's workshop and finish before Wednesday. Write working answers for your project; mark missing evidence or decisions and how you will resolve them. These prompts are planning tools, not required proposal headings.

1. Define the Study

Guide sections 1, 3, 4, and 6: title, background, problem, and question.

Working title. Name the subject and focus without assuming the result.

Research question. Identify the people or system, focus, context, and what you want to understand or assess. Include an intervention and comparison only when they fit your question.

Background and unresolved problem. What does the reader need to know? What remains uncertain, and why does that uncertainty matter?

Evidence behind the problem. Name a claim, its source and page or section, and the limit on what that source supports. Use your claims-and-evidence ledger.

Objective and prediction. What will you accomplish? If a hypothesis fits, state it and the evidence or reasoning behind it. Otherwise, state what you need to explore.

2. Connect Evidence, Ideas, and Methods

Guide sections 5, 7, and 8: literature, framework, and proposed approach.

Literature synthesis. State one pattern or disagreement across sources that matters to your question. Name the sources and a qualification the pattern requires.

Reason for this study. How does that evidence lead to your question? Identify the uncertainty your project will address without claiming that nothing has ever been studied.

Concepts and assumptions. What relationship or process do you expect? Sketch or describe it, name an assumption, and identify a competing explanation. Use a formal framework if it fits your project or your department requires it.

Design and material. Who or what will you study, where and when? How will you select participants, samples, plots, documents, or data? What amount is feasible, and what would justify it?

Procedure and analysis. What will you measure, observe, or ask? How will you analyze it to answer the question? Name a method source or protocol to check, and a bias or measurement problem to address.

Connection to check: My method can answer my question because...

3. Anticipate Outcomes and Test Feasibility

Guide sections 9-12: outcomes, contribution, limits, timeline, and resources.

Possible outcomes. Name an anticipated result or understanding and its evidence basis. Then name a different or inconclusive outcome and what you could learn from it. For exploratory work, avoid deciding themes in advance.

Contribution and product. What could the project clarify, and for whom? What will you deliver, such as a dataset, analysis, or thesis? Keep the possible contribution distinct from a promised finding.

Scope and limits. What will you leave outside the project? What uncertainty will remain, and where will your conclusions stop?

Resources and permissions. What access, equipment, training, advisor input, or review must be in place? Who can confirm what is needed?

Plan the work. Put tasks in dependency order. Include time for feedback and revision; use your actual project dates.

Table 1: Working project timeline.

Task and prerequisite	Target date	Sign of completion

Contingency. If access, recruitment, or data collection falls short, what will you change while keeping the question answerable?

4. Assemble the Proposal and Choose a Revision

Guide sections 2 and 13-15: summary, references, appendices, and conclusion.

Summary, after drafting. In a few sentences, connect the problem, question, approach, and possible contribution. Label preliminary work as completed and anticipated results as expectations.

Reference check. Check each item when you have verified it.

☐ Each in-text citation matches a reference entry, and each entry is cited.
☐ Central claims match the original sources and retain needed limits.
☐ Names, dates, titles, and reference details are checked.
☐ Citation style follows the assignment or department requirements.

Appendices, if needed. What supporting instrument, protocol, or table would help a reader evaluate the plan? Where will you refer to it in the text? Keep explanations essential to the design in the main proposal.

Argument check or brief conclusion. Trace the evidence, unresolved question, objective, method, possible outcome, and contribution. Where does the chain hold, and where does a connection need work?

Partner check. Ask a reader to explain the question and method from your map or draft before you explain it aloud. Record one supported connection and one missing explanation, piece of evidence, or decision they identify.

Next revision. Name the change, its location in the proposal, and why it matters. If you cannot resolve it now, name the source to revisit, search to conduct, or specific question to ask your advisor.

My next action and target date: _____